

Power Outage & Emergency Preparedness Review

Sakura Gardens Senior Living · Senior Living · Osaka, Japan

Document ID	SL-05
Category	Emergency Preparedness
Classification	Operational
Date	2025-11
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1. Event summary

On 16 September 2025 a typhoon caused a grid power outage lasting 3 hours 20 minutes. The standby generator failed to start automatically because its starter battery was flat; it had last been tested four months earlier, without load. Staff started it manually after 26 minutes. During that gap two lifts stopped, trapping a resident and a carer for 35 minutes; nine residents using oxygen concentrators were switched to oxygen cylinders by nurses; and room temperatures rose to 31°C because the air-conditioning was off. Emergency lighting worked as designed.

2. Root causes

- Generator tests were quarterly and off-load, so they did not prove the set could take load, and nobody monitored the starter battery.
- The generator alarm panel was not connected to any remote monitoring.
- Critical medical devices had no uninterruptible power supply (UPS).
- Lifts had no automatic rescue devices to reach the nearest floor on power loss.
- The evacuation plan assumed day-shift staffing levels.

3. Actions

- Monthly on-load generator test (one hour at 50% or more load) with automatic starter-battery monitoring and alarms.
- Generator and fuel alarms connected to a 24/7 remote monitoring service.
- UPS for oxygen concentrators, the nurse-call system and medication refrigerators.
- Automatic rescue devices fitted to all lifts, bringing the car to the nearest floor and opening the doors on power loss.
- Night-shift evacuation drills and a register of residents who need assistance.

4. Results (12 months)

The generator started at the first attempt in 12 out of 12 monthly on-load tests. All nine oxygen-dependent residents are on a UPS-backed supply, and every night shift has completed an evacuation drill.

5. Lessons learned

- Test like you mean it: an off-load test proves little. Test under real load and monitor the parts that fail silently, such as starter batteries.
- Protect the people most at risk first: map every life-critical device and make sure it has backup power.
- Plan for the worst shift, not the average one.